Murder Mystery

Dinner Party 2026



Reed DeLabel

The Meridian Museum

October 30, 2026 / Private player packet / 1 of 12

Reed DeLabel

Doctoral Fellow in Art History

Reed reads every label aloud, including the exit sign. Reed is the youngest scholar attached to the exhibition and has been trying very hard to behave like this is normal.

- **Dr. Art E. Fact** supervises Reed's doctorate and rarely returns a clean draft.
- Gets informal guidance from **Claire O'Scuro** on exhibition labels and curatorial work.
- Checks dates and catalog references for **Paige Turner**. Reed saves any article that includes a correction.
- **Anne E. Dote** coaches Reed through gallery tours. She keeps crossing footnotes out of the children's handouts.

ACTING TIPS

Eager, cerebral, anxious in a useful way, unexpectedly bold when the evidence is on your side.

YOUR INTRODUCTION / READ THE BOX ALOUD

> I'm Reed DeLabel. I am the graduate fellow. I know where the footnotes go and, more dangerously, where they are missing.

Continue to your private briefing on page 3. Keep the packet facing you.

Reed DeLabel

Tips for a Successful Dinner

What's at Stake

Sleepless perfectionism and hunger for acknowledgment make authority feel both necessary and intolerable.

Best Practices

- Everyone, including you, has something to hide, something at stake. But only one guest tonight is guilty of murder.
- Mingle using the relationships on your introduction page. Feel free to improvise in conversations.
- If a named guest is absent, simply speak to someone else. Not everyone made it to the gala tonight.
- By now, you should have drawn a secret animal. Memorize it and don’t share it with anyone. This animal is YOUR key to knowing whether you are the murderer or innocent tonight. This will tell you which sections of this packet you can read out loud.
- When asked to read from this packet, please read the appropriate box as written. Feel free to add your own flair to stay in character.
- Don't let anyone else see what's in your packet!



STOP! Do not turn the page yet.
Wait for the host to announce the next round.

Reed DeLabel

The Game is Afoot

The Meridian Museum has its share of secrets, rumors, and lost paperwork. Sixteen numbered envelopes are hidden around the museum. Their contents may significantly help you tonight. These 3 hints lead to 3 different hiding places. If you find an envelope, bring it to your seat at the table. The guest with the most envelopes will win a special prize. You may investigate together.

1 *Four legs and a metallic seat guard a secret from below.*

2 *Behind a cupboard's closed doors, one item has no domestic purpose.*

3 *Seek the sacred book with two testaments. Tonight its pages shelter evidence.*

STOP **STOP! Do not turn the page yet.**
Wait for the host to announce the next round.

Questions for the Room

Choose a named guest who has not answered. Skip absent names. Ask their question; they answer from page 6, then choose the next guest.

Artie Ficial / Monet Bags / Sue Venir

What would Grant's terms change for the museum or your family?

Claire O'Scuro / Chip Patina / Dr. Art E. Fact / Reed DeLabel

What problem in the collection work could Grant use against you?

Vincent Van Faux / Elon Mosaic / Penny Pincher

What dispute did your dealings with Grant leave you hiding?

Frank Lloyd Wrong / Elle Loominate / Al Baster / Anne E. Dote

What would Grant change about your commission or public program?

Paige Turner / Mona Lott / Robin Banks / Justin Tyme

What did Grant want made public, and what did you not want made public?

Dada DiCapo / Barb Dwyer / Brie DeVivre / Cary Crates

What did Grant expect you to deliver, and why did that put you in trouble?

Your speaking box is on page 6. Turn only within this act.

Reed DeLabel

Your Answer

Read only the bordered words when asked. Keep your packet facing you. After answering, ask an unheard guest their question from the previous page.

IF INNOCENT

I found the missing document and changed the bowl entry. Grant wanted the old settled-ownership wording. I wanted the correction credited. Yes, credited to me. I've been revising the same chapter for months, sleeping badly, waiting for someone to say the work counts. Claire asked for another draft. Grant called it a student's publicity stunt. I wasn't particularly gracious about either.

IF MURDERER

I found the missing document and changed the bowl entry. Grant wanted the old settled-ownership wording. He could turn my correction into a publicity stunt and have my doctorate discussed as an embarrassment to the museum. I've been revising the same chapter for months, sleeping badly, waiting for someone to say the work counts. He could make the finding vanish behind the person who found it.

STOP

STOP! Do not turn the page yet.
Wait for the host to announce the next round.

Questions for the Room

Choose a named guest who has not answered. Skip absent names. Ask their question; they answer from page 8, then choose the next guest.

Artie Ficial / Monet Bags / Sue Venir

What did you change about the announcement, accounts or private arrangements?

Claire O'Scuro / Chip Patina / Dr. Art E. Fact / Reed DeLabel

What did you change, handle or keep from the incoming loans and their paperwork?

Vincent Van Faux / Elon Mosaic / Penny Pincher

What did you keep out of the handout, demonstration or publicity?

Frank Lloyd Wrong / Elle Loominate / Al Baster / Anne E. Dote

What did you change when the installation and gala plans were disputed?

Paige Turner / Mona Lott / Robin Banks / Justin Tyme

What did you record, circulate or give to the people at the gala?

Dada DiCapo / Barb Dwyer / Brie DeVivre / Cary Crates

What did you do about the performance, privacy or private service?

Your speaking box is on page 8. Turn only within this act.

Reed DeLabel

Your Answer

Read only the bordered words when asked. Keep your packet facing you. After answering, ask an unheard guest their question from the previous page.

IF INNOCENT

I cut the original-contents sentence from the bottle's press entry. It wasn't a space problem. Grant had called my bowl research a publicity stunt; I wanted his harmless caption in print under his own name. Intake kept the full query. Claire, I thought if something went wrong with his precious acquisition, he might finally have to answer a question. I was thinking of a public disgrace. I didn't ask what else could go wrong.

IF MURDERER

I kept both bowl labels and shortened the bottle's entry for the press. Intake kept the full file and purchase attachment. Grant wanted to approve every correction. I went to his private place with the shortened caption. No Grant. I put it beside his glass and took it back before I left. Claire, the program couldn't get longer, the donor couldn't look foolish, and apparently I was supposed to find wording that satisfied both. I was tired of being useful.



STOP! Do not turn the page yet.
Wait for the host to announce the next round.

Questions for the Room

Choose a named guest who has not answered. Skip absent names. Ask their question; they answer from page 10, then choose the next guest.

Artie Ficial / Monet Bags / Sue Venir

What happened to the toast and the announcement?

Claire O'Scuro / Chip Patina / Dr. Art E. Fact / Reed DeLabel

What was actually on display, and what had your department been told?

Vincent Van Faux / Elon Mosaic / Penny Pincher

What do you know about the bottle, pictures, or technology you brought tonight?

Frank Lloyd Wrong / Elle Loominate / Al Baster / Anne E. Dote

Could the work or the tour have hidden what happened?

Paige Turner / Mona Lott / Robin Banks / Justin Tyme

What part of the story have your sources left out?

Dada DiCapo / Barb Dwyer / Brie DeVivre / Cary Crates

What did people actually see, hear, and drink?

Your speaking box is on page 10. Turn only within this act.

Your Answer

Read only the bordered words when asked. Keep your packet facing you. After answering, ask an unheard guest their question from the previous page.

IF INNOCENT

> Original contents. That's the sentence I cut from the press copy. Intake had it; I made sure of that. I wanted Grant caught out, in public, under his own lovely harmless caption. Claire, don't call this a misunderstanding. I was pleased with the edit. I still want my work credited. I don't know what you expect me to do with both of those things.

IF MURDERER

> I cut a credit line. The original-contents sentence wasn't the deletion. Intake had the purchase attachment for senior staff. Claire, please let me finish this answer. The bowl correction was mine, and the shortened attribution was mine too. I am tired of starting over when someone important frowns. I did not decide that a bottle's contents could be described as harmless.

The shared discoveries and reports remain at the Evidence Table.



STOP! Do not turn the page yet.
Wait for the host to announce the next round.

BALLOT

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Choose one attending guest. Explain your accusation in your own words. Detach this page and give only the ballot to the host for tallying. Keep your packet for Coming Clean.

I accuse...

Because...

Best Actor

Best Costume

Reed DeLabel

The Last Word

Read only when the host calls you. Top three suspects read first. Use your own role's box; keep every other word private.

IF INNOCENT / READ ALOUD WHEN CALLED

I did not kill Grant. My marked proof sends the complete query to intake and the shortened caption to the press. I removed a warning to finish a page. Claire, I want my work credited. I also want to stop needing your approval to know when something is wrong. Those are separate things. I will send the uncut entry myself, even if nobody thanks me for making it longer.

IF MURDERER / READ ALOUD WHEN CALLED

I removed the original-contents sentence. The marked proof is mine. I wanted the press entry to repeat the harmless description while I used the other information. During the preview I took poison from the bottle. Later I put it in Grant's waiting glass. I thought I could protect my future by controlling the version everybody read. I wanted my name on the work. It will be on this instead. Claire cannot revise that for me, and I cannot ask her to.

Every selected suspect gets their final word.